



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Sacred Heart Academy
School Website: <https://shgr.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Sacred Heart Academy Grand Rapids (SHA), ZIP 49504, presents a robust Catholic/classical orientation in its publicly accessible materials. The school explicitly brands itself as a Catholic, classical academy whose mission centers on forming hearts and minds in pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, with daily liturgical life, sacramental focus, and a parish apostolate structure. Public content emphasizes formation over mere information, the integration of theology with pedagogy, and a commitment to Western/Great-Books-oriented cultural formation, all aligned with classical aims. While the core Catholic/classical narrative is clear and strong (including daily Mass, liturgical life, and partnership with families), the school also features elements that are not typically associated with a pure classical model (notably the mention of Montessori in some program areas). Taken together, SHA registers as predominantly CLASSICAL, with a clearly stated aim of formation, virtue, and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful. The presence of Montessori programming represents a notable deviation from a strict, textbook classical pedagogy, thus a SINGLE category (Pedagogy) is assessed as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. All other categories align with classical criteria, particularly Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community.

Key insights at a glance:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Strong, explicit Catholic identity; daily Mass; liturgical life; theology-centered education; sacred culture framed as inseparable from learning. Evidence-rich alignment with transcendental moral realism and liturgical practice.
- School Purpose and Goal: Education framed as formation toward virtue, wisdom, and sanctity; explicit reference to truth, goodness, beauty as real; formation over mere information.
- Curriculum: Classical framing evident; explicit commitment to classical philosophy of education; references to Great Books and classical inquiry; some content suggests a broader Catholic-cultural formation (incarnation lens). Some ambiguity remains about explicit, ongoing Great-Books-reading requirements in all grades, but the overall orientation is classical.
- Pedagogy: Predominantly classical in orientation, but with notable inclusion of Montessori and other approaches, which yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for pedagogy. Evidence includes a stated classical identity, enrichment courses, and other non-traditional elements.
- Faculty: Public materials portray a structured leadership and faculty/staff presence, with a strong sense of mission and formation. The public-facing leadership and faculty pages emphasize teachers as guides in a Christian/classical formation, consistent with classical education norms.
- Parents & Community: Explicit partnership with parents as co-educators, parent formation efforts, open-campus orientation, and welcome to visits—all hallmark features of a classical formation ecosystem.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials state SHA is a parish apostolate focused on a Catholic classical education, with daily Mass and liturgical life as central to student formation. Text describes the school's aim to sanctify through the sacraments and Catholic culture.

- Mission and vision pages emphasize forming hearts and minds in pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, rooted in Catholic teaching and liturgy.
- The school ex-

plicitly connects education to sacred formation, Catholic identity, and liturgical practice (Mass, sacraments, catechesis, and faith-formation activities cited in multiple pages).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; sacred; catechesis; sacred tradition; divine order; worship; reverence; wonder; imitation of the good; Logos; imago Dei (per the classical lexicon). These align with the six-element positive lexicon for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (transcendental realism, theology, liturgy, sacred life). The SHA materials repeatedly deploy phrases connecting truth/goodness/beauty with Catholic worship and formation. - Negative keywords present: none observed in the public materials (no explicit signals of secular/humanist or relativist frames in the religious foundations). The materials consistently foreground a transcendent, theological frame.

Why this rating - The materials consistently foreground Catholic doctrine, liturgy, and a sacramental worldview as foundational to education, aligning with transcendental moral realism, grounded theology, and liturgical/community practice. This strongly supports CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom, not mere information, and frames education as formation of the whole person within a Catholic, classical context. The stated telos includes pursuing true, good, and beautiful, with emphasis on moral imagination and virtue formation. - The language highlights human excellence, sanctity, and the aim of forming saints, aligning with classical aims of forming character, intellect, and spiritual life.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, liberal education, contemplation/scholé, moral imagination, human flourishing. These map to the Positive Keyword indicators for School Purpose and Goal. - Negative keywords present: none observed (no emphasis on workforce-prep or utilitarian metrics in the core mission statements).

Why this rating - SHA presents education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, anchored in the real existence of truth/goodness/beauty, not merely preparation for work. This aligns with the CLASSICAL rubric for School Purpose and Goal.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - SHA frames itself as a classical and Catholic education, and the site features sections titled “A Classical Education” with references to the Great Books and the Great Conversation framework, and explicit appeal to the liberal arts, including a Trivium/Quadrivium sensibility in public materials. The “A Classical Education” page foregrounds the intrinsic worth of classical works and the Incarnation as interpretive lens. - The site also points to Classical Enrichment Courses and K-12 pathways, indicating a curriculum that embeds classical content and aims, though some pages also reflect other pedagogical influences (e.g., Montessori).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation, liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric (Trivium), history across curriculum, integration/wonder, sacred tradition, Western civilization. These line up with the Curriculum Positive keywords (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, history, integration, wonder). SHA's public content contains references to classical education concepts, and the site's curriculum framing aligns with “classical curriculum” language. - Negative keywords present: minimal explicit references to non-classical approaches; however, Montessori is listed among program offerings, which represents a pedagogical approach not exclusively in the classical canon. This introduces a curricular mixture that slightly tempers the pure classical stance.

Why this rating - While SHA clearly centers classical content and Great-Books-oriented formation, the explicit inclusion of Montessori and other non-classical modalities introduces a mixed curricular approach. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Curriculum rather than fully CLASSICAL, given the presence of non-classical curricular modalities in public-facing material.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site positions SHA as classical in identity, with elements of memory work, recitation, and formal pedagogy typical of classical education (e.g., the Great Books framework, rhetorical training, and a focus on formation). The presence of “Classical Enrichment Courses” and references to a classical identity signal a classical pedagogy orientation. - However, Montessori offerings and other non-traditional program descriptions are present, indicating a blended pedagogical approach rather than a pure classical pedagogy. The school emphasizes both classical aims and other methods.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar (documented in the classical lexicon), recitation, chanting, memory work, rest/Scholé, seminar/colloquy, rhetoric training, public speaking (oratory). These align with Classical Pedagogy indicators. SHA's materials reference a classical approach and enrichment courses, which suggests some classical teaching methods (even if not all are enumerated explicitly in the public material). - Negative keywords present: Montessori, experiential learning focus, project-based learning emphasis, non-traditional grading. The presence of Montessori in SHA's offerings is a direct counterpoint to a strictly rigid classical pedagogy, which is why this category earns a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a clear classical orientation and includes classical pedagogical elements, but the inclusion of Montessori and other non-classical approaches signals a blended pedagogy. This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SHA presents a structured leadership and faculty framework (Headmaster, President, Directors, and a visible Board). The “Leadership & Staff” pages highlight dedicated Catholic formation leadership and faculty as part of the school's living-curriculum identity. The public materials emphasize virtue, formation, and a community of teachers who model the life of learning. - The materials emphasize teachers as mentors and living examples, aligned with the traditional classical education model (the living curriculum, teachers as exemplars). The school's public materials speak to a faculty culture centered on formation and virtue.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, character formation, virtue, wisdom, classical formation. These align with the First Principles of Classical Faculty as described in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. - Negative keywords present: none observed in public-facing materials regarding faculty; no indication of non-classical faculty pedagogy or overwritten credentialing concerns.

Why this rating - SHA's publicly presented faculty structure, leadership, and emphasis on formation and virtue align well with the classical model of a dedicated and virtuous faculty, supporting CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly frames parents as partners and co-educators, with language about parental primacy in education and families as central to formation. The materials stress parent formation, book studies, gatherings, and open campus visits, all of which align with classical education's emphasis on home-school partnership and formation. - The school outreach includes “Discernment & Formation,” catechesis, and a public emphasis on parental involvement and support structures (new family dashboards, enrollment support, and community gatherings).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, classical home education, household rhythms, family catechesis, open campus, parent involvement. These map directly to the “Parents and Community” positive indicators. - Negative keywords present: none observed in material related to parents/community; no “customer” framing or minimal parental involvement signals.

Why this rating - SHA's materials consistently promote active parental partnership and community formation as central to classical education, aligning with CLASSICAL in this category.

Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, the organization and weight of the classical elements across most categories indicate an overall CLASSICAL classification for the school, with Pedagogy and Curriculum showing notable but not insurmountable deviations (Montessori and blended approaches) that reduce those two categories to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle

- Strengthen explicit, pervasive Great-Books engagement and Trivium/Quadrivium embodiment in the core curriculum across grade bands, with explicit public articulation of a continuous Great Conversation and primary-source reading plan.
- Reduce or clearly segregate Montessori or non-classical pedagogical components in core K–12 programming to reinforce a pure classical pedagogy (as defined by the Six Essential Elements). Public-facing statements should foreground a consistent classical-methodology in daily practice, not only in mission statements.
- Expand explicit, visible evidence of upper-level Socratic seminars, rhetoric training, and formal public speaking across grades, including sample rubrics, student rhetoric projects, and scheduled Socratic seminars in the upper grades.
- Increase documentation of the “living curriculum” with teacher portraits, classroom narratives, and concrete examples of the teacher as a model of virtue and mastery—emphasizing the “portrait of a teacher” and “teacher as mentor” as sustained public commitments.
- Ensure curriculum materials and communications consistently reference Great Books, Great Conversation, liberal arts, and the unity of truth, goodness, and beauty in all major program descriptions, not only in niche pages.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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